

Wired Together

So you've been getting all these e-mail invitations from pals and colleagues and uncles, and you're wondering whether you should take out the time to click the link and fill in a boring form. Sometimes the person is a vague memory; sometimes, the site has a ridiculous name. So should you click those links and sign up? What's in it for you? Thinking about that got us into writing what follows

We aren't sure: some of you have heard a lot about social networking sites and the general phenomenon, and possibly are members of many; for some of you, it might be a new thing, and you're wondering what precisely "Join my network on ZongaBonga!!" means. (Aside: what wastebasket do they get all these site names from?)

Well, in either case, we've got something for you here. We introduce the phenomenon—yes, it's nothing short of that—of social networking; and then, we tell you in this book about what's out there, which sites you might want to join, and so forth. In short, we're trying to tell you: get online, get social, have fun, talk business, flirt, and anything you can think of.

Another little aside: we believe a majority of you have heard the word "Orkut," and in a way, we're building upon that. Orkut is just one of hundreds.

A table of contents follows, listing out all the categories of social networking sites that exist—there are special interest sites, sites for social bookmarking, for finding friends, and many, many more. One look and you might just be amazed how much of a social Web it really is.

It's a phenomenon, we said, but it goes beyond. Networking and interacting with people on the Internet is the way ahead: we're getting more and more virtual. It's now normal to consider virtual beings your friends and colleagues. Something your father just won't understand. Don't bother explaining.